intensity and unfathomable ambition of wild young China."[8] Galbraith and Bowles continued to believe that India was "the only Asian country which really stands in [China's] way."[9] Overall, however, the hope that India could be built up as a contrast or counterbalance to China gave way to fear that India would collapse, causing the noncommunist world to suffer a major ideological defeat. And the idea that the US should help cure India's ailments was replaced with the focus on just stemming the bleeding. This meant helping India enough on the defense front that it was protected, but not so much that India focused only on military cures.

Debating Defense

Just after the war, Defense Department official Paul Nitze, who was part of a team sent to India, estimated that it would take India at least a year, if not more, to get into a "good military position."[10] The State Department believed that China was unlikely to back down, and said it was uncertain whether or not Beijing would resume the fighting in 1963.[11]

There was a desire in India for the US to help the country achieve that good military position. In a poll of Indian legislators conducted between December 1962 and February 1963, 96 percent wanted India to accept military supplies from the US. Furthermore, 58 percent wanted India to cooperate very closely with the US—a significant increase from the 21 percent who had wanted to do so in 1958. Pollsters also found a substantial increase in support for cooperation with the US among the public; 94 percent of respondents wanted India to cooperate "very closely" with the US and UK, a 19 percent increase from the summer of 1962. Comparatively, there was a 27 percent drop in support for very close cooperation with the Soviet Union.[12]

Officials like the Indian ambassador to Moscow urged caution and advised Delhi against accepting certain amounts and kinds of military assistance, particularly for air defense. He warned that it could lead Moscow to take China's side, especially if there was an expanded war. But an irked foreign secretary retorted that India should "harbor no illusions" about the Soviet Union, which would not have minded Chinese threats or expansionism had they paved the way for the Indian Communist Party coming to power in Delhi. He argued that Moscow was unlikely to jettison India because it was not in the Soviet's interest to do so, particularly in the